

to go. You can text me. I am happy to keep meeting with you, or you can text the center, where you could get a break for a while. (*Lukas walks out, slamming the door.*)



Lukas continued to use heavily for a few more weeks, occasionally calling or texting the therapist but not showing up for an appointment. When she got him on the phone for a few minutes, she continued to listen to his parts and reflected that some of them needed a different life, while some wanted to keep using. She also asserted that his using parts were trying to help him and wondered if they didn't need a break too. A month later, Lukas was arrested for shoplifting. He was offered the option of substance use treatment and went to a local center. After that, he entered a halfway house, looked for work, and returned to his IFS therapist.

After returning to therapy, Lukas and his therapist interviewed his using parts, and they identified these parts' clear desire to take him away from or medicate his abandoned, wounded exiles. He was curious about recurrences and discovered that his using parts had a message for him about exiles who needed attention. He learned that his using parts wished he would be more autonomous when his caretaking, compliant managers worked to avoid conflict with his mother or with certain friends. He also got connected to an LGBTQ+ Alcoholics Anonymous (AA) group, which gave him a supportive new social community.

By listening to every one of his using parts, Lukas was able to create his own vision for the future. Some of his parts were in alignment with the AA commitment to sobriety from alcohol, but he did have other parts who still wanted to smoke cannabis and relax with friends occasionally. Because of his occasional cannabis use, no one would sponsor him, but he did discover other AA friends who were not wedded to AA's clean and sober mantra and who were experimenting with their own version of a productive and balanced life.

EXILE INTERVENTIONS

Whenever clients focus internally, they can get flooded with the warded off memories and feelings of exiles, which is called an *exile jailbreak*. In response, firefighters will activate instantly. They may distract (for example, through dissociation), or they may start hunting for some way of soothing (*I want chocolate!*). Meanwhile, managers will get anxious and start to criticize. Our job, as Schwartz says, is to be the eye of the storm. Accordingly, we ask protectors to let us reassure the exile and negotiate with it to be patient.

For example, Irina, a thirty-five-year-old, Slovenian American, partnered, gender-neutral person, first came to therapy for posttraumatic stress disorder and chronic restrictive eating patterns. In past sessions, most of their protectors would agree to unblend, but then a dissociative part would promptly blend whenever they approached young exiles. This left Irina unable to focus or respond to questions. In this session, the dissociative part finally agreed to refrain from taking over, and Irina started to hyperventilate.

INTERVENING FOR AN EXILE



Therapist: Are you there? Hi, Irina. I see that a panicked part has taken over. I'm going to talk with it directly. Are you there? (*Irina nods.*) Would you like help? (*Irina nods.*) Great. You're welcome here. We want to help you. Here's what you can do to make sure we can help you. Are you listening? (*Irina nods.*) Great. Give Irina a little space. If you let them in, even just a little, they can help you.

The therapist uses explicit direct access to connect with a panicked exile.

Irina: (*They shift and begin to look calmer.*) Okay.

Therapist: How's that?

Irina: Better.

Therapist: How do you feel toward this panicked part now?

Irina: I'm glad I can breathe now.

Therapist: Does it hear you? (*Irina nods.*) And how do you feel toward it?

Irina: I want to help it.

Irina now has access to their Self.

Therapist: Ask what it needs from you.

Irina: Attention.

Irina's protectors hear that the exile only needs what Irina is actually capable of providing. This will calm them.

Therapist: Is it willing to be patient while you negotiate with protectors so that you can give it the attention it needs? (*Irina nods.*) Great. What does it need to seal the deal right now?

Irina: It needs to know that I'll be back.

Therapist: We will not forget. You will be back. Would it like to go to a safe place to wait for you?

Irina: Yes.

Therapist: Help it find the right spot, Irina.

Irina: Okay.

Therapist: You've got it?

Irina: Yes.





When protectors are not ready for an exile to tell its story but the part blends anyway, we have to intervene. We speak to it directly, negotiating with it to unblend and promising that we won't forget to give it the attention it craves. At the same time, protectors have the opportunity to see that exiles have an agenda too, and that they won't overwhelm the system if they get what they want.

One-Way Connections with Exiles

Exiles can appear early in treatment in subtle ways that befit their position on the backburners of consciousness. For instance, they often pop into a client's current narrative and divert the client's attention to the past. Say the client is reporting a stressful incident at work when, without preamble, they pivot to an earlier time (...*like when my father left and my mother fell apart...*) with no awareness of the memory's significance.

When an exile pops up like this, we pause, notice, and make the most of this connection opportunity by inviting it into the session. If the client has enough Self-energy, we may guide them to tell the exile that we won't hear its whole story now but that we know it's important and we are aiming to hear it as soon as all parts agree. We don't want to pursue these trailheads vigorously before protectors are ready, but the contact can be warm, even if it's brief. Success in therapy depends on connecting with these parts safely. If it feels right, the client may want to ask, "Is there is one thing, just for today, that you want me to know about you?"

In addition, when we sense the client is feeling vulnerable but hasn't noticed, an exile is probably making an appearance. In this case, we might say something like, "We've been discussing your relationship with your partner and his recent drug use. You haven't mentioned this yet, but I'm sensing a sad part underneath your frustration. Is that possible?" We can then invite the client to pause and focus internally. If the client insists that they do not feel the sadness, we let it go for now. If they do notice the feeling, even just briefly, we guide them to let the part know that they feel it and are aware of its presence.

As the client connects with their sad part, an image may appear, or the client may simply feel the sensations that go with sadness. Again, if there is enough Self-energy, we guide the client to stay with the sad part a little longer and have a short exchange. We guide the client to ask it not to overwhelm the system so that protectors will trust it and give it a real chance to be heard. If the sadness does start to flood the client, we can ask the exile what would happen if it unblended instead. Exiles often overflow the dam because they fear being put out of mind again. They don't trust the Self yet, and they assume a full-on deluge is their only way of being noticed. As therapists, we must work with our own parts to stay present and connected—helping the client validate the exile's fears while asking for cooperation and promising to return.

We can then direct a client to identify how and when this vulnerable exile first made its appearance. (*I was feeling angry and sad about my partner using drugs all the time, and then I remembered how sad I was when my dad left.*) Then the client can track their pattern—feeling sad, lonely, ashamed, and so on—and notice how those feelings connect to present-day actions. Since protectors are terribly afraid of exposing exiles to more judgment and injury, they need to feel good about the Self before they will allow a full connection between exiled parts and the Self. Observing moments of one-way connection—tendrils of contact between the client's Self and the exile that establish a template for safe relating—allow protectors to grow more comfortable, which sets the stage for the exile to tell its story when the time is right.

To see how this looks in practice, consider the case of Graham, who was a fifty-two-year-old, Scottish American, heterosexual, cisgender father of two sons who were in college. He described his deceased mother as being chronically depressed and his father, who was now in a nursing home, as authoritarian and punitive.

After immigrating to the United States from Scotland as a teenager, Graham attended university, pursued a career in software development, and got married in his twenties. He also developed a serious preoccupation with pornography around this same time, which had escalated over the years and included regular visits to massage parlors. His wife divorced him three years ago due to ongoing arguments about his porn use and her suspicions about the massage parlor visits, which he had been denying.

Graham had since chosen to attend 12-step meetings and attended an online support group with the stated intention of staying sober, as they called it, from pornography and massage parlor visits. He reported feeling okay with these expectations but still struggled with feelings of loneliness and shame. As of this session, he had been in therapy for about six months.

A ONE-WAY CONNECTION WITH AN EXILE



Graham: I've been really down this week. I've got a deadline at work and there is so much pressure. I went to see my father who, as usual, was terrible to me. He is a miserable man. I don't know why I go. I guess my manager part says I have to see my father.

Therapist: Sounds like that part is trying to do the right thing, but it comes at a big cost. Being around him is really hard on your more sensitive parts.

Graham's Manager: He's a mean person. He yells at the nurses all the time. He criticizes me constantly. You know, I never told him about the porn or anything, but it's like he knows. The other day he told me that the divorce was my fault and I drove her away!

Therapist: It's hard to spend time with him, yet you remain loyal. Is that confusing? (*Graham nods.*) Let's check on these parts. You mentioned one who says you have to see your father, and then you have others who always feel hurt by him.

The therapist names his polarity between parts who feel alienated and a loyal young parentified part who wields a lot of power.

Graham: Yeah, let's do that.

Therapist: Take a few breaths and focus inside on the part who says you have to see your father. What does it say?

Graham's Manager: I owe it to him. I can't leave him there all alone.

This is the parentified young manager.

Therapist: And how do you feel toward this part, Graham?

Graham's Exile: I don't like it. I feel trapped.

Therapist: That is another part. It feels trapped and sounds more tender.

Graham: When I was a boy, my father used to come to the table where I did my homework and stand over me. Sometimes he would grab my papers and scream at me that I was no good and didn't work hard enough.

Therapist: Wow, that's rough. And you were so young. The boy is showing this to you? (*Graham nods.*) Can you see him?

Graham's exile has started to show his experience and Graham has enough Self-energy to continue safely.

Graham: He's terrified.

Therapist: Let him know that you see him. Back then your father was big and scary. But the part doesn't have to stay in that time. He could be with you if he prefers.

Graham: He sees me.

Therapist: How do you feel toward him?

Graham: I feel bad for him. He's little.

Therapist: Ask him to look at you and let him know you care about him. Your heart is open.

The therapist facilitates the Self-to-part connection.

Graham: He likes that.

Therapist: Let him know we can't hear his whole story today, but we do want to hear it, and we'll keep coming back. Is there one thing he wants you to know right now?

Graham: (*He listens intently.*) He was trying so hard to make his father happy. But he was always scared.

Therapist: Are you taking that in? (*Graham nods.*) He tried hard. We will come back to him. Would he like to wait someplace safe till then?

Graham: With me.

Therapist: Great. Keep him with you.

Graham: He wants to curl up under a blanket and sleep in my bedroom.

Therapist: Perfect. Now take a moment to shift back to the manager part who says you have obligations to your father. Did it observe you helping the boy?

Graham: Yes. It's calmer now.

Therapist: Great. Thank it for stepping back for now and trusting you to reach out to that vulnerable little boy.

Graham: Okay, yeah. It wants me to take care of the boy.



In this session, Graham became aware of an exile, and his Self connected with this exile's protectors, which helped him feel more stable. Managers and firefighters all need ongoing reassurance that the Self will show up and be reliably available to vulnerable parts. Graham's case example includes a common IFS intervention called a retrieval (Schwartz & Sweezy, 2020). Notice that Graham invited his young boy to wait someplace safe until they could connect again. Utilizing imagery to invite a vulnerable part to exit an emotionally charged or dangerous scene and settle in a safer location is a surprisingly effective means for increasing inner system stability and forging trust with the Self. Offering a brief, but successful, one-way connection paves the way to develop a fuller two-way relationship.

Two-Way Connections with Exiles

A one-way connection introduces the exile to the Self and helps the exile see that the Self is not a protective part. The Self might simply say, "Hey! I'm here, I care, and I want to get to know you better." A two-way Self-to-exile connection, on the other hand, is more complex. As protectors have repeated experiences of feeling validated by the Self and understood (*Maybe I can actually count on someone inside to pay attention and be supportive!*), they are able to relax for longer periods of time. This gives the exile a seat at the table. Communication flows better and the Self has the opportunity to demonstrate that it is a stable, steady resource.

As protectors see the Self in action and step back, the exile becomes bolder about speaking for its needs. With the Self as a witness, the exile experiences a long period of connection, sometimes lasting more than one session, which offers what the part has always needed: compassion, safety, and validation. This, in turn, brings optimism and hope. Building the client's capacity for more complex inner connections is like strengthening a muscle. Consistent Self-to-part connections create a new template and boost trust in the Self throughout the internal system.

For example, Jamie was a forty-five-year-old, single, lesbian, cisgender, Irish immigrant. She worked as a teacher, lived alone, and had not been in an intimate relationship for many years. She had always seen herself as overweight and reported that she had been struggling with overeating and depression since her mother's death the previous year. She had built good connections with her team of inner critics who had long been polarized with her comfort-eating part.

While therapy was helping her feel less depressed, she still went into what she called an "eating trance" in the evening and on weekends. She had identified an eight-year-old comfort-eating firefighter—a girl who liked to hide in the pantry and sneak snacks. She was a very young protector who had been rejected and shamed by her mother's inner critics and her own inner critics for decades. In therapy, Jamie had helped her critics ease up quite a bit, but not entirely. They were still protecting another eight-year-old part—a sad, neglected little girl in a lot of pain. In this session, Jamie established a two-way connection with both eight-year-olds.

A TWO-WAY CONNECTION WITH AN EXILE



Jamie: I need to go to that young eating part. She needs attention. I ate so much over the weekend!

Therapist: Sounds good. As you spoke about eating over the weekend, were you seeing the comfort-eating part? Or can you feel her in some way now?

Jamie: Well, I feel the critic who is so disgusted with the eating. But I get it! I understand why she's worried about eating that much. She hears me. She's stepping back.

Therapist: Okay. Do you see or feel the girl who wants to eat?

Jamie: I see myself standing in my kitchen with bags of chips and dip and stuff.

Therapist: Great. Let her know you see her.

Jamie: I'm telling her that I'm here and I see her.

Therapist: How do you feel toward her?

Jamie: I feel bad for her. She seems kind of desperate.

Therapist: Show her that you care, in whatever way seems right. (*The therapist pauses.*) Ask if she's willing to talk with you.

Jamie: Yes. She's sick of being in the kitchen.

Therapist: Invite her to be somewhere else with you. (*Jamie nods.*) And if it feels right, let her know she can bring a snack with her.

The therapist suggests that Jamie welcome the firefighter as she is, without asking her to change.

Jamie: Really? That's okay? (*Tears well up in her eyes.*) She can't believe it! She can't believe it's really okay to eat with me. She's bringing the chips.

Therapist: How do you respond?

Jamie: I'm telling her it is okay. She is okay and I'm good being with her—and her food!

Therapist: That's right, you care about her.

Jamie: (*She speaks after a period of silence*) She's only eight years old.

Therapist: How is she trying to help?

Jamie: She comforts me. She knows I'm lonely.

Therapist: Another part of you is lonely and needs comfort. Does she know that part?

Jamie: Yes. It's actually another eight-year-old. Her mother watched TV and ignored her.

Therapist: Can this girl see you?

Jamie: Yes. I see her and she sees me. I feel so bad for her. She's filling her face. She needs that food so bad, but she is afraid of being caught!

Therapist: There are two girls, right Jamie? The sad, lonely one and the one who protected her by binge eating for comfort.

Jamie: They're twins.

Therapist: Would they like you to be in the pantry with them? (*Jamie nods.*) They're safe with you. Can they feel it? (*Jamie nods, teary.*) I see the tears, Jamie. How are you doing?

Jamie: It's good to be with them. But I feel sad for them, too. I guess they were sad all the time.

Therapist: Let them know you feel their sadness and desperation. What do they want you to know about that time?

Jamie: They couldn't help it. They loved hiding in the pantry. It smelled good and felt cozy. Her mother didn't want her eating in there. She'd get furious and go off, so they were always afraid of getting caught.

Therapist: They needed the comfort of the pantry and the food. Eating made the sad, lonely one feel a little better, but their mother was scary. Take some breaths together so they feel you being with them.

Jamie: They're feeling me. This is different.

Therapist: Thank them for being willing to take this chance with you. Shall we put the pantry somewhere safe so their mother can't rag on them? (*Jamie nods.*) Where should it be?

Jamie: The moon.

Therapist: Okay. Put them and the pantry on the moon and tell them you'll be back. Can you stay in connection with them this week? (*Jamie nods.*) Great. Arrange that.

The therapist invites the client to set up a retrieval for the young girls, relocating them to a safer location.

Jamie: (*She pauses, then nods.*) They feel a bit better. They see that maybe I can help. They're relieved.

Therapist: Yes. The comfort eater has been working hard all by herself to protect the sad one. What if, going forward, the sad one could count on you to be there?

Jamie: They're not totally sure about that. They like being together.

Therapist: Right. Of course. We don't want to separate them if they want to be together. Would they like us to come back? (*Jamie nods.*)



Jamie's compassionate connection with this young, protective comfort eater paved the way for an equally strong connection with the lonely eight-year-old. If we listen, young protectors and vulnerable exiles can tell us just what they need. A client's concerned managers—and sometimes a therapist's caretaking parts as well—tend to worry that exiles have near insurmountable pain and therefore need some kind of massive intervention to feel better. In fact, exiles need exactly what they needed when they were hurt: a loving, attuned connection with a dependable, courageous guardian.

Therapist Handout**Creating Safe Connections with Exiles****A One-Way Connection**

The one-way connection, which includes a firsthand experience of warmth, acceptance, and connection, introduces the exile to the Self and demonstrates that no strings are attached. For many exiles, this experience is novel. Some are immediately relieved, while others are skeptical. They see that the Self is different from protective parts and their controlling or distracting agendas. The Self offers kind attention, the opportunity to belong, and the promise of ongoing support. Every Self-to-part connection increases stability within the system. As the Self-to-part bond strengthens, it develops into a more complex, two-way street relationship. To begin creating a safe one-way connection with an exile, invite your client to try the following:

- Identify a vulnerable part.
- Guide a connection to the Self via imagery or activation.
- Check for Self-energy and reassure the part that it is not alone anymore.
- Send care and compassion to the part.
- Let the part know that you can't hear its whole story now.
- Ask the part what it wants to share just for today.
- Reassure the part that you will return.

A Two-Way Connection

A two-way connection between the Self and exiles is free-flowing and trusting. The exile shares important stories and is, in turn, nurtured by the Self's validation and acceptance. In order to unburden, the exile may just need to share painful experiences and feel validated, but if it's stuck in the past, it will need the Self to come back to that time to do what it needed someone to do for it then. With each interaction, the Self earns more trust and license to lead. To begin creating a safe two-way connection with an exile, invite your client to try the following:

- Identify a vulnerable part.
- Guide a connection to the Self via imagery or activation.
- Check for Self-energy and reassure the part that it is not alone anymore.
- Send care and compassion to the part.
- Invite the part to share whatever it is holding.
- Witness and honor the part's experience.

- Spend time gazing at, reflecting with, and embracing the part.
- Reassure the part that you will return.

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WITNESSING AND UNBURDENING

Clients in therapy who are addressing extensive periods of substance use or other compulsive behavior may have episodes of intrusive imagery or sensations that relate to traumatic events in the past. These images and sensations often reflect exiled parts who are breaking through consciousness in an effort to get help. These parts have been burdened with bad memories, shocking feelings, and negative beliefs as a result of the traumatic event. Many of these beliefs have to do with being irreparably damaged, unlovable, shameful, or disgusting. These negative beliefs can operate unconsciously for decades, profoundly affecting the individual's view of themselves and the world. As a result, they show up in client stories repeatedly.

Sometimes a client's protectors will see the Self as just another part who doesn't have the capacity to tolerate exiled pain, causing their fear to shoot up whenever the client approaches an exile. They seem to be checking: *Are you really ready for this?* However, the reality is that the client's Self is ready to step in and reverse negative judgments about the part. It is ready to witness the exile's story, validate its experience, and assert its inherent value and lovability. When a client is Self-led, they show up alert and open-hearted, and exiles get the sustained care, understanding, and protection they've always needed. As a result, they let go of distorted perceptions about themselves and the world. The client who is present and compassionate to their own story will be liberated to know what they know, feel what they feel, and speak honestly without self-attack.

In this Self-led state, the client—and, if the exile wishes, the therapist—can bear witness to the exile's story through a process known as *witnessing*. Here, the exile may want to show or tell the Self about its experiences in detail, taking the Self to see a seminal scene; it may summarize its experience; or it may just say,